

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Warehouse and Distribution English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Warehouse associates, receivers, pickers, packers, returns staff, and inventory clerks.

All cases, quantities, codes, people, and arrangements are fictional English practice, not warehouse, equipment, lifting, hazardous-material, or safety training. Local stock controls and duties vary. Use employer training for physical tasks; refer equipment operation, hazardous conditions, inventory adjustments, and release decisions to the responsible qualified staff. Scripts teach communication, not handling methods.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Receiving against the expected shipment

Separate receipt facts from a purchasing decision.

02 Locating and identifying stock

Clarify an item-location conflict before relying on the location sign.

03 Picking the right unit and quantity

Prevent a correct number being used with the wrong unit.

04 Reporting a short pick and replenishment need

Request a quantity-specific check without treating reserve stock as immediately pickable.

05 Packing and label discrepancies

Name the conflicting identifiers and request a focused check.

06 Staging and dispatch status

Explain why prepared goods are not yet a completed dispatch.

07 Returns and stock status

State a return's actual status without inferring saleability.

08 Inventory and shift handoffs

Hand over count evidence, remaining work, and ownership.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Receiving against the expected shipment

Separate receipt facts from a purchasing decision.

CASE

Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons. Receiving counts twenty-two with matching item labels. The supplier has not explained the additional two; the clerk can flag an overage but cannot approve an order change.

Teach this move

A matching label does not by itself approve an order increase.

Vocabulary to check: advance shipping notice, receiving discrepancy, purchase order, overage.

Model response

Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons, and our receiving count is twenty-two. The item labels match, but we haven't confirmed why there are two extra cartons. I'll report an overage against this receipt. Please keep the expected quantity unchanged until the purchasing contact clarifies whether the additional goods belong to this order.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. Arrival changes the observed count, not automatically the order.

Second-round challenge

A colleague suggests replacing the expected quantity with the count. Explain why both figures matter.

Language-check answers

1. C - overage Correct. Twenty-two against twenty creates a two-carton overage.
2. D - the received item's identity Correct. Labels support identification, not approval of extra quantity.

05 • Conversations

1. Two cartons above the order - Receiving clerk and buyer discuss purchase order 740.
2. The shipping notice names another site - A receiver queries an arrival notice with a carrier driver.
3. One arrival divided between purchase orders - A receiver checks an apparent overage with a purchasing clerk.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The delivery has one fewer pallet

Notice A09 expects four pallets; three arrive. Each pallet's carton contents remain unchecked. Supplier has not confirmed a separate shipment.

Role A: Receiver: state the missing handling unit accurately.

Role B: Receiving clerk: ask whether the count concerns pallets or cartons.

Possible opening: We received three of four pallets, not three of four cartons.

Success checks

- State one pallet short.
- Do not invent contents quantity.
- Ask for the matching packing detail.

Add a complication: Someone wants to call the missing pallet twenty missing cartons without a packing breakdown.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Locating and identifying stock

Clarify an item-location conflict before relying on the location sign.

CASE

A picker needs item BK-14-B, blue folders. Bin A12 contains BK-14-G, green folders. The bin sign says BK-14-B. Inventory clerk can check the putaway record; no move or substitution has been approved.

Teach this move

Product, variant, lot, and location identify different things. Repeat the full code.

Vocabulary to check: stock keeping unit, bin location, lot number, putaway.

Model response

The task calls for BK-14-B, blue folders, but the cartons in A12 are labeled BK-14-G, green folders. The bin sign agrees with the task, not the carton labels. Could you check the putaway record for these two variants? I haven't treated the shared BK-14 prefix as proof that they are interchangeable.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The suffix identifies a different variant.

Second-round challenge

A matching photograph is offered as proof. Ask for the full item identifier instead.

Language-check answers

1. C - suffix Correct. The suffix is the ending of the code.
2. D - bin location Correct. A12 is the named warehouse storage position.

05 • Conversations

1. Blue on the task, green in the bin - A picker reports item identification conflicts in A12.
2. A lot number is not a shelf number - A warehouse associate asks a colleague to clarify an instruction.
3. A location changed but the sign did not - A picker queries a revised stock location with inventory staff.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A similar item description without its code

Pick request says 'large clear box'; two variants exist: BX-L with lid and BX-O without. Order line specifies BX-L.

Role A: Picker: ask for the full identifier.

Role B: Order clerk: read BX-L and the with-lid description.

Possible opening: Does large clear box mean the lidded version or the open version?

Success checks

- Confirm BX-L.
- Name the lid distinction.
- Keep any substitution separate from identification.

Add a complication: A colleague offers the open version because its dimensions match.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Picking the right unit and quantity

Prevent a correct number being used with the wrong unit.

CASE

Pick ticket S18 asks for six each of a storage tray. A standard case holds six trays. A coworker reads it as six cases. Confirm one case contains the six requested units, without assuming other products share that pack size.

Teach this move

Say the amount and unit together. A case pack varies by item.

Vocabulary to check: unit of measure, each, case pack, pick ticket.

Model response

S18 calls for six each, meaning six individual trays. The listed case pack for this item is six, so that quantity corresponds to one complete case, not six cases. Could you read back the order quantity with its unit? We should keep this item's pack size separate from any other tray variant.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The phrase removes the unit ambiguity.

Second-round challenge

Another tray has a case pack of eight. Explain why the S18 calculation does not transfer to it.

Language-check answers

1. A - individual Correct. 'Each' counts individual units.
2. B - to Correct. 'Applies to' identifies the relevant item.

05 • Conversations

1. Six trays rather than six cases - Two pickers clarify the counting unit on S18.
2. A pair is the selling unit - A picker clarifies a glove order with the order desk.
3. The decimal belongs to weight - A picker checks a stock line with a warehouse clerk.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Three cartons of ten, not ten cartons

Order X16 asks for thirty each; item record states ten per carton. A partner says ten cartons because ten is prominent on the label.

Role A: Picker: clarify all three quantities.

Role B: Partner: confirm thirty individual units in three complete cartons for this item.

Possible opening: Which number is the order quantity and which is the pack size?

Success checks

- Keep thirty each as requested.
- Explain three cartons of ten.
- Do not apply the neighboring variant's pack size.

Add a complication: A neighboring variant contains twelve per carton.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reporting a short pick and replenishment need

Request a quantity-specific check without treating reserve stock as immediately pickable.

CASE

Order D55 needs ten baskets; pick face B04 has four. System lists twelve in reserve, but allocation and availability have not been checked. Replenishment desk can review; cutoff is 15:00.

Teach this move

Reserve quantity, order allocation, and completed replenishment are different statuses.

Vocabulary to check: short pick, replenishment, reserve stock, allocation.

Model response

Order D55 needs ten baskets, and B04 currently has four, leaving a six-unit short pick. The system lists twelve in reserve, but I haven't confirmed whether they are available to this order. Could you check allocation and replenishment status before the three o'clock cutoff and tell me whether the remaining six can be supplied?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised update names the actual dependency.

Second-round challenge

The replenishment request is accepted. Explain why accepted does not yet mean the pick face has been refilled.

Language-check answers

1. A - six Correct. Ten minus four leaves six.
2. B - allocation Correct. Allocation shows whether the stock belongs to another order.

05 • Conversations

1. Six baskets short at B04 - A picker calls the replenishment desk about D55.
2. The reserve quantity is committed elsewhere - A picker discusses unavailable reserve stock with an allocation clerk.

3. Replenished in the record, not at the location - A picker checks a task-status discrepancy with a stock associate.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A partial replenishment

Request R50 asks for eight units. Four have reached the pick location; four remain unconfirmed. Order clerk asks whether the request is complete.

Role A: Picker: report four supplied and four outstanding.

Role B: Clerk: you need a clear status for packing, not a new stock promise.

Possible opening: Have all eight arrived, or only the first four?

Success checks

- State the partial quantity.
- Distinguish acknowledgment from replenishment.
- Ask who owns the remaining four.

Add a complication: A task acknowledgment is mistaken for physical completion.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Packing and label discrepancies

Name the conflicting identifiers and request a focused check.

CASE

Packing station 3 has cartons C70 and C71. C70's screen names Harbor Shop, but the loose label beside it names Hillside School for C71. No label has been applied. Ask the packer to pause the label match while both references are checked.

Teach this move

Physical proximity does not prove that a loose label belongs to a carton.

Vocabulary to check: packing station, shipping label, carton identifier, scan confirmation.

Model response

Please pause the label match at station three. The screen for carton C70 names Harbor Shop, while this loose label names Hillside School and C71. Nothing has been applied yet. Could we compare both carton identifiers and their records before continuing? The labels' position on the bench doesn't establish which order they belong to.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the observable mismatch.

Second-round challenge

A successful scan is offered as proof of correct packing. Ask which identifier was scanned and what that scan confirms.

Language-check answers

1. D - loose Correct. The label remains unattached beside the cartons.
2. D - whereas Correct. 'Whereas' contrasts the two records.

05 • Conversations

1. Two neighboring cartons and one loose label - A checker interrupts a label mismatch at packing station 3.
2. A scan acknowledged the wrong identifier - A packer clarifies a scan result with a systems support clerk.
3. The old address on a replacement label - A packer queries a replacement label with the shipping desk.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One order, two carton identifiers

Order N40 has cartons N40-1 and N40-2. Both loose labels read N40-1; neither is applied.

Role A: Packer: describe the duplicate identifier.

Role B: Shipping clerk: verify the missing N40-2 label record.

Possible opening: Do we have two different carton labels or two copies of the first?

Success checks

- Identify the duplicated N40-1.
- Keep carton and order identity distinct.
- Request the N40-2 label check.

Add a complication: A colleague says matching customer names are sufficient.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Staging and dispatch status

Explain why prepared goods are not yet a completed dispatch.

CASE

Three cartons for order L66 are staged in lane 2. Manifest lists only two. Carrier cutoff is 16:00; goods have not departed. Dispatch clerk can investigate the missing carton entry.

Teach this move

A staging location, manifest entry, and departure confirmation provide different evidence.

Vocabulary to check: staging lane, load manifest, carrier cutoff, dispatch confirmation.

Model response

L66 has three cartons staged in lane two, but the load manifest lists only two. Nothing has departed yet, so the order is staged, not dispatched. Could dispatch check the missing carton entry before the four o'clock carrier cutoff? I can confirm the physical count without claiming that the load list is complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The update preserves the unresolved loading record.

Second-round challenge

Carrier collection is delayed. Give the current staged status without inventing a new departure time.

Language-check answers

1. A - staged Correct. Staged goods await their next transport movement.
2. A - of Correct. 'Two of the three' expresses a subset.

05 • Conversations

1. Three staged, two on the manifest - An outbound associate updates the dispatch clerk about L66.
2. The carrier arrived before collection completed - A warehouse associate clarifies a status with customer service.
3. A lane number mistaken for a departure time - An associate checks an ambiguous outbound instruction.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The departure record belongs to another load

Order V18 is on afternoon load A2. A screen shows morning load A1 departed; V18 remains staged.

Role A: Associate: explain which load the departure applies to.

Role B: Customer service clerk: you need V18's current status.

Possible opening: Does that departure confirmation name A1 or A2?

Success checks

- Match V18 to A2.
- State V18 is staged.
- Do not transfer A1's departure status to A2.

Add a complication: The clerk assumes all today's orders left with A1.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Returns and stock status

State a return's actual status without inferring saleability.

CASE

Returned kettle K25 matches its return reference. Packaging appears unopened, but condition review is pending. Intake worker cannot mark it ready for sale; returns checker Mira owns the review.

Teach this move

A return can be identified and received while its condition remains unverified.

Vocabulary to check: returns intake, inspection hold, disposition, restock.

Model response

K25 matches the return reference, and its packaging appears unopened. That appearance does not confirm its condition or eligibility for restocking. The return is received and awaiting Mira's inspection decision. Please keep the inspection hold distinct from available stock until the returns team confirms the disposition for this item.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The change names the unresolved review.

Second-round challenge

A colleague calls the item defective. Correct the label: uninspected does not establish a defect.

Language-check answers

1. C - received on inspection hold Correct. The goods are received but remain unreleased pending inspection.
2. D - disposition Correct. Disposition is the decision about the next stock status.

05 • Conversations

1. Unopened appearance is not release - A returns worker explains K25's status to a picker.
2. A returned item differs from its approval - A returns worker queries an item mismatch with the returns desk.
3. Review completed but disposition still pending - A returns worker checks a confusing status with a returns checker.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A replacement approved before the return arrives

Customer service approved a replacement for order T16. The original item's return is booked but has not arrived at intake.

Role A: Worker: separate replacement approval from physical return receipt.

Role B: Customer service clerk: confirm only that replacement was approved.

Possible opening: Has the original item reached intake, or has only the replacement been approved?

Success checks

- State original not received.
- Preserve replacement approval as a separate event.
- Ask for the expected return reference.

Add a complication: The clerk calls both actions 'return complete.'

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Inventory and shift handoffs

Hand over count evidence, remaining work, and ownership.

CASE

Cycle count for item T9 in B11 found eighteen; the system shows twenty. No cause is confirmed. Evening clerk Sam can review transaction history. Recount is complete and agrees at eighteen; no stock adjustment is approved.

Teach this move

A reliable recount can establish a difference without explaining it.

Vocabulary to check: cycle count, inventory variance, transaction history, shift handoff.

Model response

T9 in B11 counted eighteen on both counts; the system shows twenty. The two-unit variance is confirmed, but its cause isn't. No adjustment has been approved. Sam, please review the transaction history and take this discrepancy into the evening handoff. Can you confirm that you'll investigate the difference without treating a proposed explanation as established?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The correction removes an unsupported accusation.

Second-round challenge

A transfer appears in history but its timing is unclear. Explain why a possible explanation still needs checking.

Language-check answers

1. D - confirmed Correct. Both counts agreed at eighteen physical units.
2. D - unapproved Correct. No adjustment approval has been recorded for this variance.

05 • Conversations

1. Two counts agree, the system differs - An inventory worker hands T9 in B11 to evening clerk Sam.
2. A movement after the count - An associate clarifies an apparent inventory contradiction with a clerk.
3. The handoff recipient cannot take the task - A picker and outgoing clerk find the actual owner of an unresolved order.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unfinished recount at shift end

First count: fourteen; system: fifteen. Recount has started but is not complete. Incoming clerk Arun can finish it.

Role A: Worker: hand over the incomplete recount accurately.

Role B: Arun: accept the recount, then review any remaining variance.

Possible opening: Which figure is confirmed, and which check is still underway?

Success checks

- State first count and recorded quantity.
- Keep recount incomplete.
- Name Arun without claiming a finished result.

Add a complication: Someone labels the variance verified before the recount finishes.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases, quantities, codes, people, and arrangements are fictional English practice, not warehouse, equipment, lifting, hazardous-material, or safety training. Local stock controls and duties vary. Use employer training for physical tasks; refer equipment operation, hazardous conditions, inventory adjustments, and release decisions to the responsible qualified staff. Scripts teach communication, not handling methods.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Hand Laborers and Material Movers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/transportation-and-material-moving/hand-laborers-and-material-movers.htm>

OSHA: Warehousing Overview

<https://www.osha.gov/warehousing>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.